Office for National Statistics

Labour Force Survey (LFS) Data Users' News

April 2020

This is the first edition of the LFS Data Users' News – a newsletter which will keep you updated on survey developments. There are many things happening, from work on improving response rates to revisions to the Sexual Orientation estimates.

Hot topics

Coronavirus

The Office for National Statistics (ONS) is working to ensure that the UK has the vital information needed to respond to the impact of the COVID-19 pandemic on our economy and society. This means we will need to ensure that information is provided faster, using new data sources and changing how our surveys operate, to ensure we provide the information necessary as the situation unfolds. The overall impact on the ONS was outlined in a statement released on 19 March 2020, with further details published in another statement on 27 March.

The ONS has already published an article on the impact of COVID-19 on labour market outputs, as well as several labour market-related articles on our webpage for the latest data and analysis related to COVID-19. There is also a webpage which summarises all of the latest analysis and data on the impact of the virus as they are released.

During the COVID-19 pandemic, the ONS teams are ensuring we are in the best position to collect respondent data, while protecting respondents and our interviewer workforce as public health guidance changes.

ONS have consulted with relevant lead analysts on additional UK requirements for a short online survey and have accelerated the launch of our new online Labour Market System (LMS). The LMS will run in parallel with the LFS for at least six months, providing us with two sets of data.

On the LFS and APS we have transitioned from face-to-face to telephone capture and are putting in place new operational processes to improve contact and response rates.

The LFS will also include additional questions to paint a picture of the impact of COVID-19. These questions will cover whether sickness absences or reduced/increased hours are COVID-19-related, and whether these are due to sickness, self-isolation or caring for others.

Transformation

The Social Surveys Transformation team have recently published findings from testing an online first, mixed-mode prototype Labour Market Survey as part of ongoing research from the ONS Census and Data Collection Transformation Programme. These published reports include a characteristics report, a technical report and a comparative estimates report. The initial results from the tests are very positive and highlight a number of areas of research that will be taken forward in coming months.

Operational research

A huge amount of operational research has been carried out over the last few months in order to improve response rates and operational processes. These include trialling changes to advance materials and between-wave text trials using Behavioural Insights techniques.

We have also implemented a responsive design approach in the Telephone Operations unit, to maximise efficiency. Responsive design is “an adaptive data-collection approach that uses information available, both before and during data collection, to adjust the collection strategy for the remaining cases.” In our case, on the LFS, we used existing respondent and household characteristics to assign a calling priority in the second week of data collection.

There are a range of projects on the use of different incentives and work is continuing to look at their impact.

Current questionnaire changes

So far this year we have made several important changes to the questionnaire.

January to March

The following are the main changes in the January to March quarter.

Civil partnerships

In January civil partnerships were legalised for non-same-sex couples. The marital status question now allows for this.

Sickness absence

‘Pregnancy problems’ is now a separate answer option in the sickness absence questions, including Illne20. It was previously within the response ‘genito-urinary problems’.

Reasons for less hours than usual

We have added several categories to the question which asks why a respondent has worked fewer hours than usual, YLess20. For example, it is now possible to choose paternity leave, shared parental leave, and adoption leave. From April there will also be follow-on questions to capture coronavirus-related changes.

Zero-hours contracts

In response to data users’ needs, we have increased how often we ask ‘Flex10’, about special working hours arrangements. Data users told us that more frequent collection of this data would help with analysing zero-hours contracts. Previously, Flex10 was only asked in wave one, quarters two and four, in the main survey only. Now it is being asked in all quarters and all waves, for the main survey, and also for the boost.

For January to March 2020, Flex10 will only be included on Government microdata and will not be released via the SRS or UKDS. This is to allow evaluation of the impact of asking this question in consecutive quarters, before it is released and used more widely.

For April to June 2020, Flex10 will be published as normal (i.e. including in the SRS and UKDS but excluding cases where data has been brought forward), with July to September 2020 then following the same instructions as for January to March 2020.

More information will be provided in the LFS user guides.

Job quality

We have added two additional job quality questions, which are asked in the first and final wave of the survey. These questions do not apply to self-employed people, and they refer to a respondent's main job only. We ask the extent to which a respondent's job offers good opportunities for career progression (JobPro). We also ask how far managers at a respondent's workplace involve employees in decision making (JobRep).

The data for the new questions will be available when the January to December 2020 APS dataset is released in March 2021.

Autism

Data users have asked for autism as an answer option for long-lasting health conditions and we have now added this to the relevant questions, including Heal20. This option includes 'Autism Spectrum Condition' and 'Asperger syndrome', and has been developed in collaboration with autism experts. A long-lasting health condition means a physical or mental health condition or illness that is expected to last 12 months or longer, or which has already lasted for longer than a year.

April to June

Passports

In April, passports questions will be added to the questionnaire for the first time, to better harmonise with the Census and to provide a non-subjective measure of nationality. Feedback from users of migration data also said that information on dual passports would be useful, and these questions allow for up to two passport-issuing countries to be recorded.

This year we will be asking the pre-existing nationality question alongside these passports questions, allowing us to compare the data and analyse the relationship between the two. The nationality question will be asked first, to avoid any order effects impacting on data from this variable.

We carried out extensive testing of the format of the passports questions. This testing showed that asking about passports was viewed as more straightforward and objective than asking about nationality.

If respondents say they have a UK and / or Irish passport, these will be coded. ID cards and other travel documents will be allowed, if they show citizenship. We will also include expired passports, provided that respondents are entitled to renew them.

Citizenship of children is of particular interest to policymakers. For this reason, there will be an extra question for children who do not have passports. Parents or guardians will be asked which countries, if any, they would apply to for passports for these children.

Questionnaire Changes we are testing this year

We will soon be testing proposed changes to the questionnaire in our annual dress rehearsal. Some of the changes we are considering are to bring the LFS into line with proposals for the 2021 Census, on topics such as ethnicity and religion. We will keep you updated on these changes.

We are also testing improvements to the terminology we use within the questions covering statutory maternity, paternity and sickness pay.

Questions we may remove

Education

Reducing the length of the education section is a priority for our ongoing work to reduce respondent burden, because this is one of the longest parts of the questionnaire.

From the April to June 2020 quarter onwards, interviewers will no longer be required to re-ask the education questions at each wave. Instead, responses will be carried forward from wave one. Questions will only need to be re-asked if respondents have gained qualifications since they were last interviewed, or if only proxy information was available previously.

We are also planning to remove questions completely when there is no obvious data need for them, and removing them does not affect the variables capturing current or highest level of educational attainment. These questions include those that require free text responses when the respondent does not know the level of the qualification: BTSubj, SCSubj, RSASubj, CGSubj, GNVQSubj, NVQSubj, and QCFSubj. The questions asking whether vocational qualifications were obtained before or after 2010 have also been identified for removal: Vocyra, Vocyrb, Vocyrc, Vocyrd, Vocyre, Vocyrf, and Vocyrg. Both sets of questions will be removed from the July to September 2020 quarter onwards; please get in touch if you have any feedback on these proposals.

Other Topics

If a respondent has taken on a second job, in which they are self-employed, two questions currently ask why: SSelfa and SSelfb. These questions have been prioritised for removal, as they have particularly long completion times.

We also intend to remove two outdated questions that ask whether homeworkers use both a telephone and a computer to carry out their work (Teleqa and Teleqb).

Headline outputs changes

LFS and APS Reweighting

The next reweighting exercise will take place in 2020. These will incorporate the 2019 Sub-National Population Projection data (published in May 2020) and 2019 Mid-Year Estimates (published in June 2020). It is expected that reweighted LFS person microdata will be published towards the end of 2020, with other microdata made available throughout the first half of 2021.

Sexual Orientation

There have been revisions to the Sexual Orientation estimates and microdata back to 2014. These revisions have been made available alongside the release of the latest 2018 Sexual Orientation Statistical Bulletin, which is available here. The three-year APS pooled microdata has also been revised and made available to users.

The revisions result from an adjustment to improve the quality of the estimates, after we identified an issue relating specifically to the coding of responses to the Sexual Orientation questions. The levels of the ‘don’t know or refusal’ response category were affected in cases which were conducted by field interviewers using mobile phones rather than face-to-face. This issue became apparent when we quality assured the latest 2018 Sexual Orientation data, when more interviews were carried out in the field to try to improve LFS response rates. The main underlying trends of the data remain unchanged, but estimates will differ from previously published figures.

LFS Longitudinal

The methodology used to produce weights for the longitudinal LFS datasets has been reviewed to achieve greater consistency with the cross-sectional LFS estimates. While the original methodology produces consistent estimates of economic statuses at higher levels (employment, unemployment, and inactivity) and consistent trends for smaller breakdowns (full-time, part-time, employees, and self-employed), the estimates for these smaller breakdowns are not consistent. To balance the need to improve this consistency with reducing the potential for increased variance in the estimates, the weighting methodology has been altered. The methodology now includes employees and self-employed as constraints to calibrate the weights, alongside unemployment and inactivity. As a result, there are revised LFS longitudinal two-quarter and five-quarter microdata available back to 2012.

SOC2020

SOC is the harmonised occupational classification used in ONS and other Government departments. It is revised every 10 years just before the Census, not more frequently because a degree of comparability is required for time series analysis. As a result, the LFS plans to switch from the existing SOC2010 based classification to the new SOC2020 version during early 2021. There are some major challenges to meeting this deadline as it requires extensive system changes to the questionnaire, derived variables, mapping tools and earnings weighting. We will provide an update in the next newsletter, later in the year.

Measuring and reporting reliability of LFS and APS estimates

A review of existing ONS publishing practices helped identify different quality threshold criteria for publishing LFS and APS estimates. It also helped provide more consistent measures and recommendations for users when using our LFS and APS microdata. Details can be found here.

We will update you again soon.

In the meantime, if you have any queries please contact us at:
socialsurveys@ons.gov.uk

Regards,
Dr. Debbie Curtis

Head of Labour Force Survey, Annual Population Survey & DART, Social Survey Division, Office for National Statistics